

ENGINEERING

IIT Delhi takes over the top slot from IIT Kanpur, pushing it to No. 2 while the BHU's Institute of Technology and the Vellore Institute of Technology move into the coveted top 10 list

■ By Shruti Maheshwari

The premier Indian Institutes of Technology have done it once again by claiming a clear lead over all other engineering institutions in the country, occasionally swapping places between themselves. Top ranker IIT Delhi (IIT-D) exchanged places with last year's topper IIT Kanpur (IIT-K) and this year's fifth ranker IIT Chennai (IIT-C) traded places with last year's fifth ranker IIT Kharagpur (IIT-KH) that has moved up to the fourth slot. The biggest gainer has been the Institute of Technology, Banaras Hindu University (BHU), which is nine places up owing to the improvement in its overall score. On the other hand, IIT Allahabad has plummeted to the 23rd position from last year's 8th—a cumulative effect of its poor performance in both factual and perceptual terms. The other surprise has been the JNTU College of Engineering, Hyderabad, that has broken into the top 25 for the first time.

Even though this year's second ranker IIT-K introduced many pioneering technologies, the latest being innovative metals for train wheels to make them lighter and sturdier, this year's top ranker IIT-D has taken the lead in innovation. More 'open electives' and the flexibility to move between them means students can practically design their own course. "You could be a mechanical student who, in addition to your core electives, acquires a parallel specialisation in electrical. You could spread it thin over a number of areas or perhaps acquire micro-specialisation in a single area," says IIT-D Director, Prof Surendra Prasad. Two M.Tech programmes—molecular science and technology and atmospheric sciences—are being planned to fill critical manpower gaps in relevant industries. A school of biological sciences is also in the process of being set up.

The top ranker also recorded a 30-35

per cent increase in its research budget, up from last year's Rs 45 crore to Rs 78 crore which will help it double its intake of Ph.D students every five years. The faculty too rakes in close to Rs 100 crore in consultancy and research projects.

"Students in their first year itself are asked to design something new, which might not be great research or a spectacular invention but it gets them into the act of creativity," says Prasad. They are consciously guided towards taking up grand challenges. Although there always is a fuss over cutting edge research, innovations that empower the common man are not neglected either. No wonder, 23-year old Nicholas Degrenne, a student of engineering in INSA Lyon in France chose IIT-D to develop his dream project on water purification units for rural areas and has teamed up with

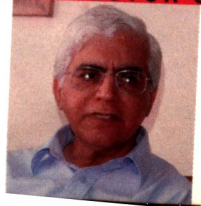
TOP 10 COLLEGES

2008		2007	2006
1	IIT, Delhi	2	1
2	IIT, Kanpur	1	2
3	IIT, Mumbai	4	3
4	IIT, Kharagpur	5	4
5	IIT, Chennai	3	5
6	IIT, Roorkee	6	6
7	IIT, Guwahati	7	-
8	College of Engineering, Anna University, Chennai	9	-
9	Institute of Technology, BHU, Varanasi	-	9
10	Vellore Institute of Technology, Vellore	-	-

National rankings are derived from a combination of perceptual and factual scores. Colleges that did not provide factual information were not ranked.
* New entrants in the Top 10. (—) Not ranked in the Top 10.

DIRECTOR SPEAK

SURENDRA PRASAD, IIT-D



"STUDENTS IN THEIR first year itself are asked to design something new which gets them into the act of creativity."

